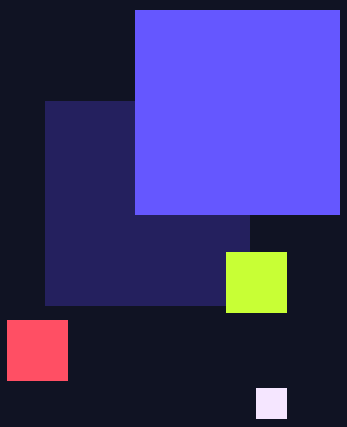


GESTALT

EXTERIOR COLOUR DESIGN

CHROMATIC DREAD · TONE-BY-TONE PALETTE GUIDE

A practical colour bible for drawing the courtyard, gate, security booth, hospital exterior, paths, vegetation and environmental anomalies. Every swatch has a job: what it is for, where it belongs, and how rarely it should appear.

THE RULE

Use the middle tones to build the material. Use dark tones to explain form. Use light tones to show the chosen light direction. Use anomaly colours only when the world deliberately breaks its own rules.

ENVIRONMENT ART DIRECTION / PIXEL ART / HEX-ACCURATE REFERENCE

01 — How to use each ramp

Each group is ordered from darker to lighter, except the signature/core group which lists the global anchor colours. You do not have to use every shade on every asset. For a small sprite, 3–5 shades is usually enough; larger structures can use more.

1. Shadow tone

The darkest one or two ramp colours describe occlusion, recesses, undersides and the side turned away from light. Use them in connected clusters. The global outline colour is not a substitute for all shadow tones.

2. Base tone

The central colour that makes the material instantly readable. This should cover most of the object's visible area. For the courtyard, start with #39A65C grass, #80265F dirt, #3830A0 gravel and #8A76A5 concrete.

3. Light-facing tone

A lighter shade on planes that face the chosen light source. Keep the direction consistent across the booth, walls, gate, trees and ground.

4. Highlight tone

The brightest ordinary shade. Use on corners, top edges, a few blades, stone faces or metal glints. It should describe form, not decorate every edge.

5. Anomaly tone

Coral, radioactive lime, impossible teal, neon rose and ultraviolet are not normal material highlights. Use them to show a meaningful perceptual break.

Colour priority

At game scale, the player should read the major shapes first: gate silhouette, side entrance, path and building. Keep the brightest accents to a small portion of the image. If every material uses its brightest shade, nothing feels important.

02 — Courtyard first-pass recipe

Start with these eight colours before adding the full ramps. This is the recommended baseline for the courtyard blockout.

Colour	Swatch / HEX	Use
Grass base	#39A65C	Broad lawn shapes and main grass fill.
Lime accent	#C8FF35	Tiny sunlit tufts or a suspicious patch; not whole lawns.
Dirt base	#80265F	Main dirt road/earth strip.
Coral intrusion	#FF4F64	Rare wrong-colour mark, not a routine dirt highlight.
Gravel base	#3830A0	Main gravel path and paving mass.
Concrete midtone	#8A76A5	Main visible wall or security-booth body tone.
Gate metal	#191D38	Most gate bars and the main closed-gate mass.
Outline	#101323	Outer contours, deep joins and strongest contact shadows.

Recommended order of work

1. Block in large flat shapes with the base tones.
2. Add dark contact shadows beneath walls, trees, posts and the gate.
3. Separate forms with a few midtones, not outlines around every object.
4. Add light-facing planes consistently across the whole scene.
5. Add small material texture clusters.
6. Add anomaly colours last, only where the scene needs a deliberate wrong note.

Value balance suggestion

As a loose guide, aim for most of the scene to sit in mid and dark values, with a smaller portion of light tones and only a few percent of very bright accents. The exact ratio depends on the camera and weather, but the gate should remain a dark barrier and the path should remain easy to follow.

SIGNATURE / CORE COLOURS

These are the global anchor colours. Some are used across several materials; others are special accents. The swatch's role matters more than using it frequently.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	Deepest Outline #101323	The darkest contour colour. Use for the outside silhouette of objects, the deepest contact shadows, gate joints and places where two forms overlap. Avoid using it for every internal line; that makes sprites look too heavy.
	Gestalt Ink #191923	A softer near-black for internal seams, small structural details, fence joins and secondary outlines. Use when the deepest outline would be too harsh.
	Blackberry Void #24205E	Deep violet shadow. Use for large shadow masses, recesses, the underside of structures and dark ground areas. It keeps the world violet rather than plain black.
	Electric Iris #6557FF	The signature electric violet. Use as a controlled accent on selected paving stones, reflected light, signs or a rare lit edge. It should be recognisable without covering every surface.
	Radioactive Lime #C8FF35	The brightest green-yellow accent. Use for a few sunlit grass tips, suspicious vegetation or an anomaly. It is not the default grass colour.
	Surgical Vermilion #FF4F64	A vivid coral-red that signals perceptual intrusion or a meaningful warning. Keep it rare in the neutral courtyard so it retains impact.
	Ghost Porcelain #F5E6FF	Pale lavender-white for small concrete highlights, pale objects, paper and ghostly edges. It is brighter than normal concrete, so avoid using it as the whole wall fill.
	False Sun #FFD447	A strong artificial yellow. Use for a small light source, a thin lit edge or a strange warm patch of ground. Its warmth should feel deliberate and slightly untrustworthy.

GRASS & VEGETATION

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#182C36 #182C36	Deepest foliage shadow: small pockets beneath tree canopies, dense tufts and grass clumps touching walls. It should not replace the global outline.
	#204B45 #204B45	Dark green shadow. Use for the shaded side of a grass clump or the underside of a bush.
	#28765A #28765A	Low/mid green. Use as a transition between deep shadow and the main lawn colour.
	#39A65C #39A65C	Main courtyard grass base. This is the default green for broad grass areas and the colour that should establish the lawn.
	#76D94A #76D94A	Bright leaf green. Use on the light-facing edge of a tuft, a few blades, or small clusters that catch light.
	#C8FF35 #C8FF35	Acid-lime highlight. Only a few pixels or a small patch at a time; it should pull the eye.
	#E7FF86 #E7FF86	Pale sickly green. Use for tiny top highlights or vegetation that feels unnaturally bright.
	#F4FFD0 #F4FFD0	Near-white green. Extreme highlight only, or a deliberate sign that a patch of vegetation is behaving incorrectly.

DIRT & EARTH

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#321D50 #321D50	Deepest dirt shadow, particularly where earth meets a wall or sits beneath an object. The violet undertone ties dirt to the overall palette.
	#54245D #54245D	Dark earth shade. Use for the shadow side of the path and clustered ground texture.
	#80265F #80265F	Main courtyard dirt colour. Use for the broad shape of the road or earth strip.
	#B52E63 #B52E63	Lighter raspberry earth. Use for a few broad lit planes and larger texture clusters.
	#E83D67 #E83D67	Hot earth highlight. Use sparingly for the most exposed dirt patches or visually strong details.
	#FF4F64 #FF4F64	Coral intrusion colour. This is not a normal dirt highlight; reserve it for deliberate perceptual disturbance.
	#FF826C #FF826C	Warm coral edge. Use in small groups where a false warm light catches earth.
	#FFB29A #FFB29A	Pale coral extreme highlight. Only a few pixels, not a routine texture shade.

GRAVEL & PAVING

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#171638 #171638	Deepest gaps between stones and dark path edges. Helps the ground read as a connected path rather than confetti.
	#24205E #24205E	Dark violet-blue paving. Use for the main shadow mass of a gravel or paved path.
	#3830A0 #3830A0	Main gravel/path base. This saturated violet-blue is the path's identifying colour.
	#5145D8 #5145D8	Mid-tone stone planes. Use in clustered groups, following the path's direction.
	#6557FF #6557FF	Electric violet accent. Use on a few light-facing stones or an occasional edge.
	#8D83FF #8D83FF	Lavender highlight. Use on selected stones that catch light.
	#B8AEFF #B8AEFF	Pale violet highlight for a small number of exposed stone faces.
	#E0D9FF #E0D9FF	Near-white stone glint. One or two pixels per cluster; too much will make gravel look glossy.

CONCRETE & HOSPITAL WALLS

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#292442 #292442	Deepest concrete shadow: door recesses, undersides, wall corners and covered areas.
	#40345E #40345E	Dark violet wall plane. Use for shaded facade sections and large structural divisions.
	#62517E #62517E	Middle concrete shade. Useful for wall areas away from the strongest light.
	#8A76A5 #8A76A5	Main readable exterior concrete midtone. Use as the primary wall or booth-body colour in the initial courtyard.
	#B4A0C9 #B4A0C9	Light-facing concrete plane. Use for one side of a wall or a broad plane under the chosen light direction.
	#D4C4E5 #D4C4E5	Pale concrete highlight. Use for edges, chipped areas or small planes, not the whole wall.
	#F5E6FF #F5E6FF	Ghost Porcelain. Use for a very bright corner or unnaturally pale patch that needs to stand out.
	#FFF8FF #FFF8FF	Near-white extreme highlight. Reserve for tiny glints or an intentional perceptual break.

BRICK & MASONRY

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#25183E #25183E	Deepest brick shadow and mortar gaps.
	#40204E #40204E	Dark brick plane, especially on the shaded side.
	#63265A #63265A	Dark raspberry brick; use for shadow clusters.
	#8B2B61 #8B2B61	Main readable brick midtone.
	#B83A68 #B83A68	Lit brick plane or a few blocks that face the light.
	#DF557A #DF557A	Bright brick detail. Use in clusters rather than individual random pixels.
	#F28CA1 #F28CA1	Pale rose highlight for chipped or exposed brick edges.
	#FFC1C7 #FFC1C7	Extreme highlight or deliberate wrong-colour mark; very rare.

METAL GATES & RAILINGS

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#101323 #101323	Deepest contour around the gate and the darkest joints.
	#191D38 #191D38	Main gate fill. Use for most bars and the overall dark mass so the closed gate reads as a barrier.
	#252B53 #252B53	Secondary metal plane for thicker posts, crossbars and shaded supports.
	#35416C #35416C	Mid-tone steel. Use on a few light-facing bars or booth fittings to separate forms.
	#50618B #50618B	Cool metal highlight; use sparingly on the side facing the light.
	#7184B0 #7184B0	Bright steel edge for a few rails or corners.
	#A1B2D8 #A1B2D8	Pale metallic highlight, especially on an exposed top edge.
	#D8E3FF #D8E3FF	Tiny metal glint only. Broad use makes the gate look shiny and safe rather than heavy.

WINDOWS & GLASS

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#14162C #14162C	Default window interior: near-black, so windows feel deep or unreadable from outside.
	#202044 #202044	Main window mass. Use for most of the glass, especially when no clear interior is visible.
	#292D60 #292D60	Subtle violet-blue plane for a pane or reflected darkness.
	#343D83 #343D83	Cool blue glass plane. Use only where a reflection helps define the window shape.
	#465CB0 #465CB0	Mid reflection colour for a small section of sky or surroundings.
	#6279D1 #6279D1	Brighter reflection; keep it to a few grouped pixels or a narrow pane edge.
	#8EA4ED #8EA4ED	Pale reflected edge. Rarely use across a full window.
	#C4D4FF #C4D4FF	Tiny cold glint. If the entire window is this bright, it stops feeling like dark glass.

LIGHTING / FALSE SUNLIGHT

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#412047 #412047	Warm-violet shadow around a light source; helps warm light blend into the purple environment.
	#71305A #71305A	Transition shade between dark surfaces and warm illumination.
	#AD4166 #AD4166	Coral light bounce on nearby ground or wall; use in a small local patch.
	#E87B64 #E87B64	Dusk-coral lit plane for a surface turned toward the light.
	#FFAA55 #FFAA55	Main amber light accent. Use for the bright area nearest a lamp or strange warm source.
	#FFD447 #FFD447	False Sun. A signature yellow, best kept to the light core or a small edge.
	#FFE88A #FFE88A	Pale yellow highlight just outside the brightest area.
	#FFF5C9 #FFF5C9	Tiny light core or extreme reflection. Do not use as a large ambient glow.

ORGANIC MATTER / MOULD

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#142E32 #142E32	Deep damp shadow, especially where mould sits in corners or beneath objects.
	#19464A #19464A	Wet teal shadow for the darkest organic clusters.
	#21665B #21665B	Dark green-teal transition.
	#28876A #28876A	Main mould/growth colour for a readable patch.
	#36A978 #36A978	Brighter growth edge, used to define the shape.
	#61CB83 #61CB83	Small brighter marks on the growth.
	#96E5A0 #96E5A0	Pale unusual patch; use sparingly so it doesn't read as friendly grass.
	#D0F5B0 #D0F5B0	Near-white growth highlight, or a deliberate sign that the organic matter is wrong.

BLOOD / PERCEPTUAL INTRUSION

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#24152F #24152F	Deep bruise shadow. Use when an anomaly needs a dark base, not as general environment shadow.
	#421B42 #421B42	First transition into the intrusion ramp; useful for a stain that is only just noticeable.
	#68204D #68204D	Dark berry cluster. Use in small grouped patches rather than a uniform overlay.
	#912653 #912653	Clear intrusion colour for a visible but contained anomaly.
	#C12D60 #C12D60	Stronger intrusion highlight. Reserve for the focal part of a mark or stain.
	#E83D67 #E83D67	Main visible anomaly red; use where the player should notice the break.
	#FF4F64 #FF4F64	Strongest routine coral warning. A few pixels can pull the eye across the scene.
	#FF826C #FF826C	Hot edge highlight for the anomaly. Avoid using it as general blood or dirt shading.

SKIN / CHARACTER TONES

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#302038 #302038	Deepest skin shadow; use under the chin, hairline, eye sockets and the far side of the face.
	#4A2947 #4A2947	Main cool shadow plane for skin.
	#69374F #69374F	Transition shade between shadow and the base tone.
	#8C4B58 #8C4B58	Main stylised skin base in this palette.
	#B76869 #B76869	Light-facing midtone for cheeks, forehead or arms.
	#D58C7C #D58C7C	Soft highlight for facial planes, hands and exposed skin.
	#EAB09B #EAB09B	Pale highlight used in small planes, not as a full-face fill.
	#F5D0B9 #F5D0B9	Extreme skin highlight, usually only a few pixels.

FABRIC / UNIFORMS / PATIENT GOWNS

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#202039 #202039	Deep fold shadow and the darkest fabric mass.
	#333354 #333354	Main dark uniform or cloth fill.
	#494A70 #494A70	Mid-tone for dark clothes; separates the lit plane from folds.
	#66658C #66658C	Blue-grey fold plane and light-facing fabric.
	#8584A7 #8584A7	Pale fabric mid-high tone.
	#AAA8C5 #AAA8C5	Lit cloth plane, useful for a readable fold.
	#D0C9DE #D0C9DE	Main pale patient-gown fill or light fabric base.
	#F0E8F5 #F0E8F5	Tiny bright fold highlights on pale fabric.

WOOD / DOORS / FURNITURE

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#2B1941 #2B1941	Deep recesses, underside and darkest grain.
	#47234D #47234D	Shadow plane for doors and furniture.
	#67304F #67304F	Main wood base; stylised plum-brown rather than natural brown.
	#8B3E53 #8B3E53	Lit wood plane.
	#B65861 #B65861	Warm mid-high tone for a panel or edge.
	#D87A70 #D87A70	Coral wood highlight where a surface catches false warm light.
	#ECA18A #ECA18A	Pale wood highlight, used sparingly.
	#FFD0AA #FFD0AA	Tiny warm glint, such as a door handle or a very exposed edge.

PAPER / DOCUMENTS / SIGNAGE

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#201B3D #201B3D	Deep printed ink, paper shadow and darkest text.
	#393052 #393052	Main dark ink for headings, rules and readable text.
	#59436D #59436D	Secondary printed text, stamps and marks.
	#795F87 #795F87	Secondary headings or worn ink.
	#A18AA8 #A18AA8	Fold shadows and aged edges.
	#C9B6D1 #C9B6D1	Main aged-paper surface or secondary paper plane.
	#F5E6FF #F5E6FF	Main pale paper fill.
	#FFF8FF #FFF8FF	Clean paper area or tiny bright edge.

REALITY DISTORTION / RARE ACCENTS

Read from darkest to lightest. Use the ramp to describe the material's form; reserve its last one or two colours for small highlights or unusual states.

Swatch	Name / HEX	What this tone is for
	#00F5D4 #00F5D4	Impossible teal. A single reflection, edge or object can use it when normal material logic breaks.
	#FF2E93 #FF2E93	Neon rose. Use in a tiny cluster for an unmistakably unnatural intrusion.
	#B8FF00 #B8FF00	Lime anomaly. Use when ordinary lime is not strange enough; do not mix it casually with grass.
	#7B2CFF #7B2CFF	Ultraviolet anomaly. A wrong-colour edge, shadow or reflection.
	#FF5C00 #FF5C00	Burnt-orange anomaly; useful for a sudden false-light mark or warning.
	#A4FFFF #A4FFFF	Cyan ghost highlight; one or two pixels can imply unstable edges.
	#FFB3E6 #FFB3E6	Pink ghost highlight for an uncanny pale mark.
	#FFFFFF #FFFFFF	Absolute white. Use only for a tiny focal pixel or a deliberate break in the colour rules.

FINAL — Applying the palette to exterior assets

Main gate

Dominantly #191D38, with #101323 for the silhouette and joins. Use #252B53 for support planes and only a few #35416C or #50618B pixels where the light catches metal. It should read as a heavy barrier, not a shiny fence.

Security booth

Use #8A76A5 as the main concrete tone, darker concrete for the underside and corners, and pale concrete only on the light-facing plane. Keep the window mostly #14162C/#202044 with a few blue reflections.

Side entrance

Choose the wood ramp only if it is actually wooden; otherwise use the concrete ramp. Darken the frame/recess, keep the door itself distinct, and use one narrow highlight to establish its edge.

Hospital facade

Use large, calm planes of #62517E and #8A76A5. Use #40345E for recesses and #B4A0C9 for a selected light-facing wall plane. Avoid making the whole building pale.

Grass and trees

Base grass is #39A65C. Use #28765A and #204B45 for clumps and shadow, then #76D94A on selected lit tufts. Save #C8FF35 for tiny focal patches.

Dirt road

Base #80265F, shadow #54245D, lighter plane #B52E63. Use coral shades only when false warm light or a deliberate anomaly justifies them.

Gravel path

Base #3830A0, darker gaps #171638/#24205E, selected midtone stones #5145D8. #6557FF and paler iris colours are small highlights, not a uniform sparkle effect.

Windows

Keep them dark by default. Add a small cool reflection from the glass ramp. An impossible-colour reflection can signal intrusion, but keep the rest of the window stable.

Exterior lights

Use the lighting ramp around a local source: warm violet at the edge, amber nearby and #FFD447 in a small bright area. Do not apply a yellow tint across the whole scene.

Signs / paper

Pale lavender paper with dark violet ink. Preserve strong contrast so the text remains readable. Coral or lime can mark one altered detail.

How to make the exterior feel wrong

• Start with a consistent light direction and material identity.

• Introduce only one violation at a time: a coral patch on concrete, a lime grass clump in shadow, or a gate shadow that falls the wrong way.

• Keep most surfaces normal. The player needs a stable baseline to notice the anomaly.

• Do not use a global colour filter as the main effect. Make the disturbance local, specific and meaningful.

• Keep Henry, doors, exits and interactable objects readable even at the lowest mental state.

Quick test: zoom out to the actual game camera size. If the gate reads as a barrier, the path leads the eye, the walls separate from the grass, and the brightest colours are still special, the palette is doing its job.